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‘ENDULKAR’

My primary goal now was to win the 2007 World Cup in the Caribbean. We had made the final four years earlier and had faltered at the very last hurdle. We were all desperate to go one better this time and expectations at home were very high.

We played well in our two practice matches against the Netherlands and the West Indies in Jamaica in early March. We scored 300 batting first against the Netherlands, for a decisive 182-run win, and in the next match our bowlers polished off the West Indies for 85, setting up a nine-wicket victory. We seemed to be getting into a good rhythm for our first group match against Bangladesh on 17 March, but at the same time there was no question of being complacent or taking them lightly. Bangladesh had beaten decent opposition before.

The match was tough for many reasons. When we batted, the pitch was damp and it was extremely difficult to play shots in the first ten overs. Mashrafe Mortaza, Bangladesh’s medium-fast bowler, was performing well and we had lost two early wickets when I went in to bat. I was batting at number four in this competition, as requested by the team management. I was perhaps a little surprised to bat in that position, because we had experimented with my batting position before, on the eve of the 2003 World Cup, only to agree that I could contribute most as an opener. But the team management’s theory was that the tracks in the West Indies would be slow and low and I would be able to manoeuvre the spinners in the middle of the innings. As it turned out, almost all the wickets had bounce and movement and the strategy backfired on us.